



ATACAMA DESERT

The Atacama is the driest desert in the world—in some parts of the desert, no rainfall has ever been recorded. Nevertheless, around 500 species of plants and a few arthropods, amphibians, reptiles, birds, and mammals have adapted to survive here. These include scorpions, salt flat lizards, Humboldt penguins, and Andean flamingos.



VALLE DE LA LUNA

PHYSICAL BARRIERS

Geographic barriers such as rivers separate animal populations, limiting their distribution and encouraging separate species to develop. Two capuchin species are separated by the Paraná and Araguaia rivers. Genetic evidence indicates that these populations separated 2 million years ago.

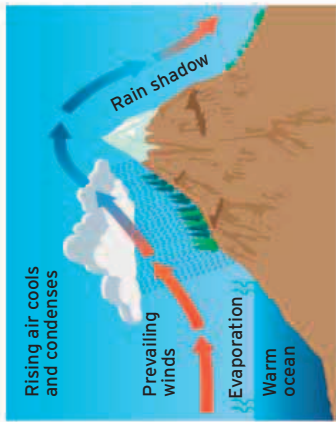


AZURA'S CAPUCHIN

FERTILE GRASSLANDS

The rich temperate grasslands of the Argentine pampas are home to many unique animals.

ANDEAN RAIN SHADOW



Much of the south-eastern part of the continent is dry due to the rain shadow cast by the Andes. Winds from the Pacific Ocean rise and cool over the mountains, causing the water vapour they contain to fall as rain on the windward (west) side of the mountain range.

FEATURED ECOREGIONS



STRAIT OF MAGELLAN

Fish move through this sea passage between the Pacific and Atlantic oceans.